Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Ephesians

Ephesians 1:1

- The frequent focus on the will of God highlights God's control in fulfilling his plan (see 1:5, 9, 11; 5:17; 6:6).
- God's holy people: Literally the holy ones, who are devoted to God (see also 1:15, 18; 2:19; 3:8, 18; 4:12; 5:3; 6:18).
- The oldest manuscripts do not include in Ephesus, and there are no personal greetings in this letter. Many scholars think the letter was originally meant to be shared among several churches in the area, not just the church in Ephesus.

Ephesians 1:1–2

Paul follows the typical style of ancient Greek letters. He starts with a brief introduction about himself, then offers greetings. However, Paul expands this basic pattern in a distinctly Christian way.

First, Paul refers to his divine calling as an apostle rather than just stating his name. This shows that his authority comes from God, not from himself.

Second, Paul describes the people he writes to as "God's holy people" and as "faithful followers of Christ." This reminds them of their special identity and relationship with God.

Ephesians 1:2

Paul often asks for God's grace and peace for his readers. Grace is a blessing from God's kindness that we do not earn. Peace is a feeling of well-being and contentment based on the good news about Jesus and brought by the Holy Spirit (see Galatians 5:22). Both are gifts from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ (see Romans 5:1–2).

Ephesians 1:3

Paul describes every spiritual blessing in the heavenly realms in 1:4–8, 13–14. Paul focuses not on physical blessings, but on what God has done through Christ to save people and bring them closer to him.

Ephesians 1:3–14

Paul praises God for all the spiritual blessings given through Jesus Christ to both non-Jewish people (Gentiles) and Jews. This section is a single, complex sentence in Greek. It is one of the longest sentences in Paul's letters. Long sentences are typical of Paul's writing (also in 1:15–23; 2:1–7, 14–16; 3:1–12, 14–19; Colossians 1:3–29; 2:1–3, 8–15). These sentences are interwoven (connected and linked together like threads that are knitted or laced together). This reflects the interconnectedness of their ideas. Interwoven sentences show that different ideas are closely connected and depend on each other.

Ephesians 1:3–3.21

Ephesians has two parts:

1. Chapters 1–3 praise God for his amazing grace.
2. Chapters 4–6 teach believers how to live in grateful response.

Ephesians 1:4

God's people are holy and without fault in his eyes because they trust in Christ's sacrifice to atone for their sins (see 1:7; 5:25–27; Colossians 1:22; Titus 3:5–7; Jude 1:24).

Ephesians 1:5

God decided in advance to adopt us into his family. By his sovereign choice, God welcomes and blesses those who trust in Christ as his children. They become heirs to all the promises God made to his people (see 1:11, 14; 2:19; Romans 8:15–17, 29–30; Galatians 4:5).

Ephesians 1:6

- Believers praise God, who has blessed them greatly with his forgiving grace.
- his dear Son: This literally means the beloved, a title for Jesus as the Messiah; see Matthew 3:17; 17:5; Colossians 1:13.

Ephesians 1:7

- In him we have redemption through the blood of his Son: Believers were once prisoners of sin. Now they are free from God's judgment and from the bondage to sin because of Christ's sacrificial death (see 1:14; 4:30; Romans 3:24; 1 Corinthians 6:20; Colossians 1:14; compare Matthew 26:28; Mark 10:45; Hebrews 9:11–12, 26; 1 Peter 1:18–19).

Ephesians 1:8–10

Wisdom and understanding come from God revealing his mysterious plan about Christ. In Paul's writings, mysterious will (traditionally mystery) often means a divine truth once hidden but now revealed in the good news (see 3:9). Here, it refers to how God will unite everything under Christ's authority, so he is universally recognized and respected as Lord (see Philippians 2:9–11; Colossians 1:16–20, 26–27; 2:2, 19;

4:3). Ephesians specifically highlights the inclusion of both Gentiles and Jews in God's redeemed people (see Ephesians 3:3–6; 6:19; compare Romans 16:25–26).

Ephesians 1:11

- In Him we were also chosen as God's own: Paul often describes salvation as an inheritance, a promise made to our spiritual ancestors and now received by us (see Romans 8:17; Galatians 3:29; 4:7; Colossians 1:12; 3:24).
- God is sovereign (he has supreme power and authority over everything). Because of this, God ensures everything works according to his plan (compare Romans 8:28–30).

Ephesians 1:12–13

We here likely refers to Jews, and you likely refers to non-Jews (Gentiles).

Ephesians 1:13

you were sealed: In ancient times, people used seals to mark items as their personal property. Just as a seal shows true ownership, the Holy Spirit in a believer's life shows God's ownership (4:30; 2 Corinthians 1:22).

Ephesians 1:14

The Spirit serves as both God's promise of future blessings and a preview of eternal life and power. A believer's eternal inheritance includes everything God promised (see also 1:18; Romans 8:17; 2 Corinthians 1:22; 5:5; Galatians 3:29; 4:7; Colossians 1:12; 3:24; Titus 3:7).

Ephesians 1:15

Paul connects faith in Christ with love for God's people. Personal faith in Christ leads to salvation. Salvation is shown mainly through a life of love (see Galatians 5:6; Colossians 1:4; 1 Thessalonians 1:3; 3:6; 5:8; 2 Thessalonians 1:3; 1 Timothy 1:14; 2:15; Titus 2:2).

Ephesians 1:15–23

Paul prays that his readers gain the spiritual understanding to fully appreciate God's gifts (1:3–14).

Ephesians 1:17

- a spirit of wisdom: The word spirit can mean the Holy Spirit or the human spirit.
- Knowing God means having a personal and experiential relationship with him, not just intellectual knowledge (see John 17:3).

Ephesians 1:18

Believers confidently hope for Christ's return and the future blessings they will share. United with Christ, they become co-heirs of all God's promised blessings.

Ephesians 1:19–20

- God's power for those who believe in him is the power of his Spirit working in and through his people, because they are connected to the resurrected Christ (see Romans 6:4–14; Colossians 2:12). Paul wanted to experience the power of Christ's resurrection in his own life (Philippians 3:10).
- In biblical times, the place of honor was always at a person's right hand (Psalm 110:1; Acts 7:56).

Ephesians 1:21

far above: Jesus has power and authority that is greater than all other powers, whether human or spiritual beings. This includes powers in the present age and in the age to come (see 3:10; 6:12; John 12:31; Romans 8:38–39; 1 Corinthians 15:24; Colossians 1:13; 2:10, 15; 1 Peter 3:22; Revelation 12:7–9).

Ephesians 1:22

under His feet: In ancient Near Eastern art, victorious kings often placed their feet on the necks of their defeated enemies. Paul uses this imagery to show how Christ has defeated all his enemies and reigns as king over everything (see Psalm 110:1; 1 Corinthians 15:25–28).

Ephesians 1:23

the fullness of Him who fills all in all: This challenging phrase likely means that the church, as his body, fully expresses Christ in this world. His presence, which fills the entire universe, is reflected in and works through his body (4:10).

Ephesians 2:1–3

Paul describes how the people he was writing to were in a terrible spiritual condition before they believed in Jesus Christ. He says they were like dead people in their relationship with God (see 2:5; Colossians 2:13). This spiritual death happened because of their disobedience and sins. They regularly did things that went against God's will and broke his commands.

Paul explains that their sinful actions were influenced by the power of the devil. The devil was working in their lives, leading them away from God and toward wrongdoing.

Because of this situation, the people Paul wrote to were under God's judgment. They were condemned along with everyone else in the world who did not follow God.

Ephesians 2:1–10

Paul thinks about how difficult life was for the believers before they found Christ. He appreciates God's grace for saving them.

Ephesians 2:2

Human sin is influenced by the devil, also called Satan, who leads the evil spiritual forces that oppose God (see 1:21; 6:11–12; compare Colossians 1:13). This same evil spirit also rules over people who refuse to obey God (2 Corinthians 4:4; contrast Romans 8:2–14; Galatians 5:22–23).

Ephesians 2:3

People who have not converted are naturally controlled by their strong desires and sinful nature (see Rom 3:9–20, 23). Because of their sin, they are subject to God's anger, because God hates sin (see Ephesians 5:6; Romans 1:18; 2:5, 8; 3:5, 19; 4:15; 5:9; 9:22; 12:19; 13:4–5; Colossians 3:6; 1 Thessalonians 1:10; 2:16; 5:9).

Ephesians 2:4–10

By God's mercy, kindness, and love, those united with Jesus Christ are saved from the terrible consequences of their sin and enjoy the benefits of Christ's resurrection.

Ephesians 2:5

- made us alive with Christ: Believers are united with Christ and share in his resurrection, now and in the future (see 2:6; Romans 6:4–14; Colossians 3:1–4).
- It is by grace you have been saved!: See Ephesians 1:2; 2:8–9.

Ephesians 2:6

And God raised us up with Christ and seated us with Him: Because of this union, believers share in God's glory and blessings. They experience resurrection both now and in the future (see Romans 6:4–14; Colossians 2:12–13; 3:1–4).

Ephesians 2:7

grace: Refer to the study note on 1:2.

Ephesians 2:8–9

This is a brief summary of how a person is saved. A key belief of the good news about Jesus is that people are made righteous by trusting in Christ. They are not made righteous by their own efforts (see Romans 1:16–17; 3:24–25; Galatians 2:16; compare John 3:16, 36). Salvation is not a reward for the good things we have done (see Romans 3:21–4:8; 9:16; Galatians 3:2–10; 5:1–6; compare 2 Timothy 1:9; Titus 3:5). Salvation is for those who trust only Christ to save them. Therefore, none of us can boast about it (compare Romans 3:27; 4:2; 1 Corinthians 1:30–31; Galatians 6:14).

Ephesians 2:10

For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works: Good works are the results of salvation. Good works do not cause salvation. God's Spirit, working through a transformed heart, produces a good life (Galatians 5:22–23).

Ephesians 2:11

Traditionally, Jews avoided Gentiles and did not consider them part of God's people. They called them uncircumcised, meaning they had not received the sign of the covenant (see Genesis 17:9–14). But Paul taught that it is shallow to judge people based only on outward signs. What matters is a person's heart and faith. In Christ, physical circumcision does not make someone part of God's family (see Romans 2:28–29).

Ephesians 2:11–22

Paul now focuses on the grace God has given, particularly to Gentiles (non-Jews). God brought them into his family and united them with Jews in a new, unified, multiethnic community. This new community is the body of Christ, the church. Paul's focus on including Gentiles suggests they might have experienced discrimination from Jewish Christians.

Ephesians 2:12

Before non-Jewish people (Gentiles) became believers in Jesus Christ, they had no part in God's people or the covenant promises God had made to them. They were without God and without hope (see 4:18; Colossians 1:21).

Ephesians 2:13

A person can only be reconciled to God by being united with Christ Jesus through trust in him (see Romans 5:10–12; 2 Corinthians 5:18–21). The blood of Christ makes this reunion possible (see Ephesians 1:7; Romans 3:24–25; 5:9; Colossians 1:20; compare He-

brews 9:12–15; 1 Peter 1:19; 1 John 1:7; Revelation 1:5; 5:9). When the Bible talks about "the blood of Christ," it is referring to the death of Jesus as a sacrifice. Through the sacrifice of Jesus, God offers forgiveness and reconciliation to all who believe.

Ephesians 2:14

- For He Himself is our peace: We have peace with God (2:16–17; Romans 5:1, 10–11, 18–21; Colossians 1:20–22). There is also peace between Jews and gentiles (see Ephesians 2:15–16; 4:3).
- has torn down the dividing wall of hostility: Social and religious practices traditionally divided Jews from gentiles. A low wall around the temple in Jerusalem marked the boundary that gentiles could not cross. It symbolized the separation Jews maintained from gentiles.

Ephesians 2:15

- by abolishing in His flesh the law of commandments and decrees: See Romans 10:4; Colossians 2:14; compare Romans 6:14; 7:4–6.
- The church is one new people. It is a community where love and acceptance are valued, and ethnic differences do not cause division (see Romans 15:7–12; Galatians 3:28; compare John 10:16).

Ephesians 2:16

Christ's death on the cross reconciles humans to God. It also reconciles Jews and Gentiles to each other.

Ephesians 2:17

- far away ... near: This verse might refer to Isaiah 57:19.
- The Greek text does not include the words Gentiles and Jews, but they are implied (see Ephesians 2:13; see also study note on 1:12–13).

Ephesians 2:18

Because of Christ's sacrifice for sins, both Jewish and Gentile believers receive the Holy Spirit. This allows them to approach God openly (see 3:12; compare Acts 10:34–37, 44–48; 1 Peter 3:18).

Ephesians 2:19

Gentiles who believe are no longer strangers and foreigners (2:11–12, 17). Through Christ, they are fully accepted into God's family. They become children of God, just like believing Jews (see Romans 8:14–17).

Ephesians 2:20

- Apostles are missionary evangelists sent by God. They travel to share the good news about Jesus with others.
- Here, the prophets seem to be from the New Testament, not the Old Testament (see 3:5; 4:11; see also 1 Corinthians 12:10, 28–29; 14:1–5, 22–24, 29–32, 39; compare Acts 13:1; 19:6; 21:9–10). In both the Old and New Testaments, prophets do not primarily predict the future. Instead, they are empowered to speak a message from God (see 1 Corinthians 12:10).
- on the foundation of the apostles and prophets: This means the church is based on their faithful witness to the saving message of Christ (see Revelation 21:14; compare Matthew 16:18). However, Christ Jesus himself is the cornerstone, the Messiah, Savior, and Lord (compare 1 Corinthians 3:11). The cornerstone is the most important stone in a building's foundation (see Isaiah 28:16; Mark 12:10; Acts 4:11; 1 Peter 2:6–7).

Ephesians 2:21

Gentile and Jewish Christians unite in Christ to form a holy temple for the Lord. The Lord is present among his people (see Matthew 18:20; 28:20; 1 Corinthians 3:16; 1 Peter 2:4–5).

Ephesians 3:1

- For this reason: Paul wrote about the amazing salvation that God's grace brings to undeserving sinners under his judgment. He also wrote about the incredible revelation that gentiles can join God's new family, the people of God (chapters 1–2).
- the prisoner of Christ Jesus: Paul wrote this letter while imprisoned for sharing his faith with the gentiles.

Ephesians 3:1–13

- Paul explains his special job in God's plan that has existed forever. His role is to announce God's grace to gentiles (non-Jewish people).

Ephesians 3:2–13

Paul pauses his thought in 3:1 to talk about his role in God's plan. When Paul first converted, God gave him the special task of sharing his grace with the gentiles (see Acts 9:15–16; 22:14–15, 21; 26:17–18; Romans 1:5; 11:13–14; 15:15–18; Galatians 1:15–16; 2:7–9; Colossians 1:25–27; 1 Timothy 2:7; 2 Timothy 4:17).

Ephesians 3:3

- Paul's earlier writing refers either to 1:9–10 (compare 2:11–22) or to an unknown letter.
- Paul understood God's mysterious plan because God revealed it to him (see study note on 1:8–10; 1:9–10; Galatians 1:11–12, 15–17; compare Acts 9:3–6; 1 Corinthians 12:1, 7; Galatians 2:2).

Ephesians 3:5

- God's holy apostles and prophets: See 1:1.
- The order of the terms apostles and prophets (see 2:20) suggests that Paul is referring to New Testament prophets, not Old Testament ones. In both the Old Testament and the New Testament, the gift of prophecy is more about delivering a special message from God than predicting the future (see 1 Corinthians 12:10).

Ephesians 3:6

God's plan that has now been revealed to Paul is that the Gentiles are now included in God's family, the body of Christ, just as Jews are. They share equally in God's eternal blessings.

Ephesians 3:7

- grace: See study note on 1:2.
- I became a servant: Paul describes himself as a servant of:
- the gospel (see also Colossians 1:23),
- of God (1 Corinthians 3:5; 2 Corinthians 6:4),
- of Christ (2 Corinthians 11:23),
- of the church (Colossians 1:25), and
- of the new covenant (2 Corinthians 3:6).

Ephesians 3:8

- Paul thought he was the least deserving of all God's people because he once strongly persecuted believers (see 1 Corinthians 15:9; 1 Timothy 1:12–16).
- unsearchable riches of Christ: See Ephesians 1:3–14.

Ephesians 3:10

- The church has an important purpose in God's plan. It is meant to show to the entire universe how wise God is. The church displays God's wisdom in all its rich variety. This wisdom is shown through how God saves people from sin and brings them into his family (see Romans 11:33–36).
- the rulers and authorities in the heavenly realms: See Ephesians 1:21 and corresponding study note.

Ephesians 3:12

We can approach God boldly and confidently. This means we can come into God's presence without fear or hesitation. This boldness in approaching God is not because of the good things we have done. Instead, our confidence comes from Christ's sacrifice for our sins. When Jesus died on the cross, his sacrifice was all-sufficient (see 2:18; Hebrews 4:14–16; 10:19–23; 1 Peter 3:18; 1 John 4:14).

Ephesians 3:13

because of my sufferings for you: Paul writes from jail as a prisoner (see 3:1). He understands that suffering is to be expected and that it works for good in a believer's life (see Romans 5:3–5; Colossians 1:24; 1 Thessalonians 3:3; 2 Timothy 3:12; James 1:2–4).

Ephesians 3:14

... for this reason I bow my knees before the Father: Paul continues what he began to say at the start of the chapter (see 3:1).

Ephesians 3:14–21

Paul ends this section (1:3–3:21) with a second prayer for the people he is writing to. The first prayer in 1:15–23 was for their spiritual understanding. The second prayer in 3:14–21 is for their spiritual growth and strength.

Ephesians 3:15–16

from whom every family in heaven and on earth derives its name: There is a wordplay in the original Greek language between the words "Father" (patēr, 3:14) and family (patria). This wordplay shows a connection between God as Father and all the families that exist. As the Creator of everything, God made all families—both angelic families in heaven and human families on earth. This includes all people groups, whether gentile or Jewish (see 2:14–22; 3:6). Because God is the Creator of everything, he has access to glorious, unlimited resources. He does not hold back these resources but gladly gives them to his children.

Ephesians 3:17

so that Christ may dwell in your hearts: Having Christ make his home in your hearts is what gives believers spiritual power for life and ministry (see John 14:16–17, 23; 15:4–5; Galatians 2:20).

Ephesians 3:18

to comprehend the length and width and height and depth: Christ's love is great in every dimension (see Romans 8:38–39).

Ephesians 3:19

- to know this love: The Christian life is based on experiencing and personally knowing God's grace and love through Jesus Christ (see Romans 12:1).
- that surpasses knowledge: Christ's love is much greater than ordinary human love (see Romans 5:6–8).
- A believer's life becomes complete when filled with the fullness of life and power through Christ's presence (see Ephesians 1:23; Galatians 2:20; Colossians 1:27). The believer then conforms to his image and reflects God (see Ephesians 4:14, 24; 5:1–2; Romans 8:29; 2 Corinthians 3:16–18).

Ephesians 3:20

Now to Him ... be the glory: God deserves nothing less because of the grace God has shown through Jesus Christ. The mighty power within us is God's power, which raised Christ from the dead (see 1:19–20). With that power, God can do much more than we ask or imagine, as God works in the lives of his children (see Romans 8:31–39; Philippians 4:13; Colossians 1:29).

Ephesians 3:20–21

A doxology is a statement of praise to God. This doxology ends the first section of Paul's letter to the Ephesians (see also Romans 16:25–27; Galatians 1:5; 1 Timothy 1:17; 2 Timothy 4:18; Jude 1:24–25). It is Paul's way of praising God for all he has described in these chapters.

Ephesians 3:21

The church, which is the community of believers including both Jews and Gentiles, should reflect and fully express God's glory.

Ephesians 4:1

- As a prisoner in the Lord: (see study note on 3:1).
- Although believers cannot earn salvation, they should live in a way that honors their calling to salvation (see Philippians 1:27; Colossians 1:10; 1 Thessalonians 2:12).
- the calling you have received: (see Ephesians 1:4–5, 11).

Ephesians 4:1–6

God's saving grace for both Jews and non-Jews (Gentiles) should guide how they interact in the church. They should welcome each other warmly, just as God has welcomed them.

Ephesians 4:1–6.20

then: Ephesians divides into two sections:

1. The first explains the good news about Jesus (the gospel).
2. The second describes how Christians should live.

This division reflects Paul's belief about the Christian life. He believed that how Christians live should be a response of gratitude for what God has already done for them through Christ.

Ephesians 4:2

with all humility ... gentleness ... patience: Believers should be like Christ in how they treat others (see Colossians 3:12–14; compare Galatians 6:2). Jesus himself demonstrated perfect humility, gentleness, and patience in his relationships with people.

Ephesians 4:3

through the bond of peace: Paul emphasizes that God accepts both Gentiles and Jews (2:11–3:6). This acceptance should guide behavior. Jews and Gentiles should accept each other in the church (see Colossians 3:14–15).

Ephesians 4:4–6

- These three verses might come from an early Christian creed (a formal statement of beliefs). These verses emphasize the unity that all believers share.
- Despite their ethnic differences, Jewish and non-Jewish Christians have one Lord and one faith. Because of this, they should live together in unity.
- Christ's one body is the church (see 1:23; 2:16).
- one God and Father of all: (see 1 Corinthians 8:6; 15:28).
- who is over all and through all and in all: God is especially present in the lives of believers (see 1 Corinthians 6:19; 2 Corinthians 13:5; Galatians 2:20; Colossians 1:27; compare John 14:16–17, 23; 15:4–5).

Ephesians 4:7

He has given each of us a gift through his grace to strengthen the community of believers (see 1 Corinthians 12:7; compare Romans 12:6; 1 Corinthians 12:11).

Ephesians 4:7–16

Though believers share a common faith, God has given different special abilities to each individual believer for building up the church community.

Ephesians 4:8

- "He led captives away": This may refer to Christ's victory over spiritual powers (see 1:21–22; Colossians 2:15). It may also refer to his capture of disobedient sinners, turning them into believers through the power of the good news.
- Christ gave gifts to his people (see Ephesians 4:11–12).

Ephesians 4:9–10

to the lower parts of the earth: This phrase has been understood in several different ways by Bible scholars. Some people have thought this phrase refers to Jesus' tomb after his crucifixion. Others have suggested it means the world of the dead, the place where spirits go after death (compare Matthew 12:40; 1 Peter 3:18–20). Still others have connected it to the coming of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost. However, the phrase most likely refers to the incarnation. The incarnation is when Jesus Christ, who is God the Son, descended from heaven and became a human being (see John 1:14; 3:13; Philippians 2:7–8).

Ephesians 4:11

- In his letters, Paul provides four different lists of God's gifts (see also Romans 12:4–8; 1 Corinthians 12:8–10, 28). None of these lists includes all possible gifts. This list focuses on the leadership gifts that help the church grow:
- Apostles are people God sends out as missionary evangelists. They travel around sharing the good news about Jesus.
- Prophets are people who speak messages from God to his people.
- Evangelists tell others the good news about Jesus.
- Pastors (which means shepherds) are people who take care of God's people (see 1 Timothy 3:1–7).
- Teachers are people who explain Scripture and God's truths to the church.
- The terms pastors and teachers might refer to two separate roles, or they might describe two parts of the same role.

Ephesians 4:12

- God gives gifts to believers to help them strengthen the church (see 1 Corinthians 12:7; compare 1 Peter 2:5).
- to equip the saints for works of ministry: All believers are called to active Christian service.

Ephesians 4:13

The goal of ministry is to help all Christians understand and experience their faith more deeply and know God's Son better. When this happens, believers become mature in the Lord (see 1 Corinthians 2:6; 14:20; Philippians 3:15; Colossians 1:28; 4:12; compare Hebrews 5:14; James 1:4; 3:2). Christ himself is the standard of maturity. The Holy Spirit's work is to transform people to become fully like Christ (Romans 8:29).

Ephesians 4:14

carried around by every wind of teaching: Mature Christians, with a strong understanding of the good news and of Christ, can identify and resist false teachings (see Galatians 1:6–7; 3:1; Colossians 2:8–23; 1 Timothy 1:3–7; 4:1–3; 6:3–5, 20; 2 Timothy 4:3–4; Titus 1:11).

Ephesians 4:16

- Each part of the body of Christ has an important role and helps other parts grow. Christ, the head of the body, works through each part. He makes them fit together. He is the ultimate source of growth (see Colossians 2:19).
- When all believers serve effectively, the whole body will be healthy, growing, and full of love (compare 1 Corinthians 8:1). Love is the most important factor in Christian growth (1 Corinthians 13:1–13).

Ephesians 4:17

God's people are called to live in a way that is different from unbelievers in the world.

Ephesians 4:17–5.20

Paul gives believers specific guidelines for living a new life in Christ.

Ephesians 4:18

Their minds are full of darkness because their minds are closed and hearts are hard (see 2 Corinthians 4:4). This means they cannot understand spiritual truths clearly. Their minds are "closed," which means they are unwilling or unable to accept God's truth. Their hearts are "hard," which means they have become insensitive to God's guidance.

Ephesians 4:19

Having lost all sense of shame: Unbelievers have hard hearts, meaning they no longer listen to God's guid-

ance. As a result, they lose the ability to know right from wrong. They do not feel guilty about doing sinful things, including sexual immorality (see Romans 1:21–31).

Ephesians 4:20–24

What you learned about Christ is the truth that comes from him. He gives true understanding (compare John 14:6). He calls his people to a completely new way of life (compare Romans 6:3–14; 13:12–14; Colossians 3:8–10).

Ephesians 4:24

to put on the new self: God's Spirit shows his life within the believer (see Colossians 3:10; compare Genesis 1:26; Romans 12:1–2; Galatians 5:22–23). The transforming work of God's Spirit is part of the gift of salvation (Ephesians 2:8–10).

Ephesians 4:25

- speak truthfully to his neighbor: (compare Zechariah 8:16).
- we are all members of one another: (see Romans 12:5; 1 Corinthians 12:12–13, 27).

Ephesians 4:26–27

- "Be angry, yet do not sin": This verse quotes Psalm 4:4. The literal form of the quotation does not justify anger. Anger gives the devil an way to influence us (see James 1:20). God's people should be gentle and gracious, not harsh or angry (see Ephesians 4:31–32).
- Do not let the sun set upon your anger: This means we should resolve our anger quickly. We should not allow our anger continue or grow stronger.

Ephesians 4:28

Christians should work hard, be honest, and care for others (see 1 Thessalonians 4:11; 2 Thessalonians 3:6–12).

Ephesians 4:29

Believers should learn new ways of speaking that encourage others (see also 5:3–4, 12).

Ephesians 4:30

- Believers must not offend or push away God's Holy Spirit, who shows that they belong to God (see Mark 3:29; Acts 5:3–5, 9; 1 Thessalonians 4:8; Hebrews 6:4–8).
- in whom you were sealed for the day of redemption: The Spirit's presence confirms that believers belong to God and guarantees their future salvation (see Ephesians 1:13–14; Romans 8:16–17; 2 Corinthians 1:22; 1 John 4:13).

Ephesians 4:32

Forgiving others who share your faith is a natural and positive response to experiencing God's forgiving grace through Christ (compare Colossians 3:12–13; 1 John 4:19).

Ephesians 5:1

- Be imitators of God: We imitate God mainly by showing love (5:2; see Matthew 5:44–45, 48).
- as beloved children: Just as children follow their parents' example, believers should follow God's example (1 Corinthians 4:14–17).

Ephesians 5:2

- Christ's love is shown especially in his sacrifice for us (compare 5:25; John 15:13; Romans 5:8). Christian love follows Christ's example of sacrificial love (see Philippians 2:5–8).
- Paul uses Old Testament imagery, where the smell of a burning fragrant sacrificial offering was pleasing to God (see Leviticus 1:9; 2:2; compare Romans 12:1).

Ephesians 5:3–5

God's people, also called the saints or holy ones, should live a holy life. They must avoid the immoral behavior common among unbelievers (compare 4:19; Colossians 3:5).

Ephesians 5:4

God's people should speak in ways that show they are thankful to God (see 4:29; 5:3, 12).

Ephesians 5:5

- Many similar statements describe the type of person who will not inherit the kingdom of Christ and of God: See 1 Corinthians 6:9–10; Galatians 5:19–21; Revelation 22:15; compare Colossians 3:5–6.
- a greedy person (that is, an idolater): The things greedy people desire become their gods (see Matthew 6:24).

Ephesians 5:6

God's anger will come during his final judgment (see Romans 1:18; Colossians 3:5–6; compare John 3:36).

Ephesians 5:7

do not be partakers: Compare 2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1.

Ephesians 5:8

- Darkness means not knowing God and being controlled by sin (see 4:18).
- Light in the Lord is the good news of Christ (see John 8:12). As people of light, believers live in fellowship with God, who has no darkness (see 1 John 1:5–7; 5:9; compare Matthew 5:14–16; John 8:12; 12:35–36, 46; Romans 13:12; 2 Corinthians 6:14; 1 Thessalonians 5:4–8; 1 Peter 2:9).

Ephesians 5:9

God's people should do what is good, right, and true. This is in agreement with God's light (compare Romans 12:2; some early manuscripts use Spirit instead of light; compare Ephesians 4:22–24; Matthew 7:16–20; Galatians 5:22–23).

Ephesians 5:10

Test and prove what pleases the Lord: The goal is to obey God's will, not simply to understand it (see Romans 12:2; Philippians 1:10).

Ephesians 5:11

but rather expose them: This does not mean to accuse or condemn people with words (see 1 Corinthians 5:9–13). Instead, it means to show what is wrong by living in a way that reflects God's light (see John 3:20–21; Romans 13:12; 1 Peter 2:9),

Ephesians 5:13–14

"Wake up, O sleeper": This could be words from an unknown Christian song. It might be inspired by texts in Isaiah (compare Isaiah 26:19; 52:1; 60:1). It urges God's people to leave their sinful ways and live in the full light of Christ.

Ephesians 5:15

Foolish people do not understand God and his ways. Wise people know God and understand his ways (see Job 28:28; Proverbs 1:7; 2:1–22).

Ephesians 5:16

- redeeming the time: See also Colossians 4:5.
- the days are evil: see Matthew 24:6–12, 15–22; 2 Thessalonians 2:3–10.

Ephesians 5:18

- The Holy Spirit, not wine, should have the most influence in the lives of believers (see Proverbs 23:29–35; compare Acts 2:15–18).
- be filled: The grammar here suggests a repeated, ongoing process of letting the Holy Spirit guide and influence the lives of believers, not a single event.

Ephesians 5:19–20

- with psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs: Lives filled with the Holy Spirit will show themselves through singing and making music (Colossians 3:16–17). Joyful praise, worship, and giving thanks are good responses to God's saving grace.
- Speak to one another: Singing together strengthens the body of Christ.
- The Lord hears the music in our hearts. The Lord knows and values our sincere worship, even when it is not expressed out loud but comes from deep inside us.
- In the name of our Lord Jesus Christ: Jesus Christ is our mediator and representative as we approach God (compare John 14:13–14; 16:23–27; Revelation 22:4).

Ephesians 5:21

- Submit to one another: The verb form connects it with the command to be filled (5:18). This general instruction (compare Philippians 2:3) applies to all three relationships Paul discusses:
- wives and husbands (Ephesians 5:22–33),
- children and parents (6:1–4), and
- slaves and masters (6:5–9).

Believers express submission not out of fear or personal gain, but out of respect for Christ.

Ephesians 5:21–6.9

Paul provides clear guidance on how believers should interact in a Christian home (see also Colossians 3:18–4:1; 1 Peter 2:18–3:7). Love and respect should define all relationships among believers as a way to show their commitment to the Lord.

Ephesians 5:22

A wife's Christian commitment includes choosing to submit to her husband as part of living out her faith (see 1 Corinthians 11:3–10; 14:34–35; Colossians 3:18; 1 Timothy 2:11–12; Titus 2:5; 1 Peter 3:1–6). At the same time, all Christians (including husbands and wives) are called to submit to one another out of respect for Christ (Ephesians 5:21). At the same time, husbands are called to love their wives and care for them sacrificially, following the example of Christ (see Ephesians 5:21–23). This mutual submission, respect, and love build a healthy, God-honoring marriage.

Ephesians 5:22–33

Christian wives should respect and submit to their husbands. Equally important, Christian husbands should love their wives (see Colossians 3:18–19). Christian marriages reflect the union and relationship between the Lord and the church.

Ephesians 5:23–24

- For the husband is the head of the wife: To be the head is to have authority (see 1 Corinthians 11:3).
- as Christ is the head of the church: See Ephesians 1:22; 4:15; Colossians 1:18; 2:10, 19.

Ephesians 5:25–33

Christian husbands should love their wives just as Christ loved the church. This means loving sacrificially, for Christ gave up his life for the church (5:2; compare Colossians 3:19; 1 Peter 3:7).

Ephesians 5:26

by the washing with water through the word: The church has been purified by the message of good news. God has forgiven the sins of his people through Christ's sacrificial death (John 15:3; compare Titus 3:5; 1 Peter 3:21).

Ephesians 5:27

a glorious church, without stain or wrinkle or any such blemish: The church's sins are forgiven through Christ's sacrifice, and the Holy Spirit purifies her life. As a result, the church stands holy and without fault before God. Compare 1:4; 2 Corinthians 11:2; Colossians 1:22; Revelation 19:7–8; 21:2.

Ephesians 5:28–29

Husbands should value and care for their wives as they do themselves. In marriage, the two become one (see 5:31). This means that caring for one's wife is like caring for one's own body.

Ephesians 5:31

The unity of husband and wife should motivate the husband to care for his wife.

Ephesians 5:32

This mystery is profound: Both the unity of husband and wife and the unity of Christ and the church are a great mystery(see study note on 1:8–10).

Ephesians 5:33

Paul summarizes his teaching on the relationship between husbands and wives (5:22–33). Christian marriages should be marked by love and respect.

Ephesians 6:1–4

The relationship between parents and children should reflect their devotion to the Lord. Christian children should obey their parents, and Christian parents should discipline their children gently (see Colossians 3:20–21).

Ephesians 6:2–3

Children who honor and respect their parents also honor and respect God. This leads to blessings.

Ephesians 6:4

- Fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath: Fathers can make their children angry by being harsh or unfair (see Colossians 3:21).
- bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord: Parents should teach their children discipline and lessons from the Lord so they learn a good way of living that pleases God. This discipline should be loving and gentle. It should not be excessive, so that children are not turned away from the Lord but are drawn to him (compare Hebrews 12:5–11).

Ephesians 6:5

Obeying human masters shows a Christian slave's service to Christ (see Colossians 3:22–23; 1 Timothy 6:1–2; Titus 2:9–10; 1 Peter 2:18–23).

Ephesians 6:5–9

- The relationship between slaves and masters (and similarly, between employees and employers) should be guided by their commitment to the Lord and their desire to support each other in Christ. Christian slaves should obey their masters, and Christian masters should treat their slaves kindly (see Colossians 3:22–4:1).
- Paul was not promoting slavery. Paul was teaching Christians how to live with it as a reality in that culture (for Paul's views on slavery, see Philemon Book Introduction, "Meaning and Message").

Ephesians 6:6–7

as servants of Christ: Believers have been bought by Christ's sacrifice. Because of this, believers do not belong to themselves anymore (see 1 Corinthians 6:19–20; 7:22; compare Romans 1:1; Galatians 1:10; Philippians 1:1). For Christian slaves, God's will is for them to

honor him by serving their human masters faithfully and with entusiasm.

Ephesians 6:8

The Bible uses the image of a master to describe the Lord's authority over believers. He will reward those who are faithful (see 1 Corinthians 3:12–15).

Ephesians 6:9

- do the same: Act with integrity and care for the well-being of others (see Colossians 4:1).
- Give up your use of threats: Christian masters will also answer to the same Master in heaven for their actions on earth. Pleasing God means treating their slaves humanely and kindly.
- there is no favoritism with Him: God judges everyone by the same standard (see Deuteronomy 10:17; Acts 10:34; Romans 2:11; Colossians 3:25). God's justice affirms the dignity of all people and calls for their freedom.

Ephesians 6:10–20

Paul's final message reminds believers about the devil's opposition. Paul urges believers to protect themselves with all of God's armor.

Ephesians 6:11

Put on the full armor of God: See Romans 13:12; 2 Corinthians 10:4–5. Only with the Lord's protection can a believer resist all of the devil's plans (compare 1 Peter 5:8–9).

Ephesians 6:12

Believers should not see other people as their enemies. Instead, their opposition comes from spiritual evil in the unseen world. Christ has authority over that realm (see 1:21–22).

Ephesians 6:13

God's armor helps believers resist the devil's attacks during times when evil seems strong, allowing them to stand firm.

Ephesians 6:14

the breastplate of righteousness: A breastplate is a piece of armor that covers the chest to protect the heart and other vital organs during battle. In the Bible, Paul uses this image to show how righteousness—being right with God and living in a right way—protects a believer's heart and life from the attacks of the devil. This righteousness is either:

- the righteousness God gives to those who believe in Christ, or
- the righteous way of life that the Spirit of God creates in believers.

Each one suggests the presence of the other.

Ephesians 6:14–17

Paul uses the armor worn by Roman soldiers as a metaphor for the spiritual armor of believers. Most of this armor is for defense, not attack. Paul is not mainly focused on the exact use of each piece, but on the gifts God gives to protect his people. Trusting in Christ and knowing the Scriptures help believers stand firm against the devil's attacks (compare James 4:7; 1 Peter 5:8–9).

Ephesians 6:15

your feet fitted with the readiness of the gospel of peace: This means letting peace from the good news (the gospel) guide your life (see Romans 5:1).

Ephesians 6:16

- the shield of faith: Faith means trusting Christ as Savior or trusting God to meet needs during difficult times. Like a shield that protects a soldier from arrows, faith protects believers from fear, doubt, and the lies of the devil.
- all the flaming arrows: Paul uses a strong picture to describe how temptation to sin can come suddenly and powerfully (compare Matthew 6:13; 26:41; 1 Corinthians 10:13; James 1:12–15). In battle, arrows were sometimes dipped in pitch and set on fire before being shot. In the same way, the devil sends dangerous temptations, but faith in God can stop them.

Ephesians 6:17

- take the helmet of salvation: Just like a helmet protects a soldier's head, the assurance of salvation protects a believer's mind. It reminds believers that God has saved them and given them eternal life through faith in Christ.
- the sword of the Spirit: This is the word of God. It is like a weapon believers use to answer attacks, either by sharing the good news about Jesus, or by speaking or remembering what God has said in Scripture (compare Jeremiah 23:29; Hebrews 4:12). A sword is a weapon with a long, sharp blade used in battle.

Ephesians 6:18

- Paul shows the difference between mental prayer and prayer in the Spirit. Prayer in the Spirit is prayer that is led by the Spirit of God living within believers. (see 1 Corinthians 14:15; Jude 1:20; compare Romans 8:26–27).
- every kind of prayer and petition: Believers should make prayer a part of daily life, turning all of life into prayer (see Philippians 4:6–7; 1 Thessalonians 5:17). This is not just for themselves, but for all believers everywhere.
- stay alert with all perseverance: The danger of the devil is constant.

Ephesians 6:19–20

- Paul's mission was to help non-Jews (Gentiles) understand they are now accepted by God and welcomed into God's church.
- the mystery of the gospel: See study notes on 1:8–10; 3:3.
- I am an ambassador in chains: Although writing as a prisoner (see 3:1; 4:1), Paul knew his role as God's ambassador was to continue speaking boldly for God (compare 2 Corinthians 5:20) .

Ephesians 6:21–24

Paul ends this letter with personal words and a blessing that repeats the desires expressed at the beginning of the letter.

Ephesians 6:23–24

- Peace ... love ... faith ... grace: These qualities are mentioned at the start of the letter (1:2, 15). Peace, love, faith, and grace are what Paul most desired for believers.
- to the brothers: Paul uses this term to refer to all members of the same family, both male and female.
- to all who love our Lord Jesus Christ with an undying love: Another way of translating this is "be eternally upon all who love our Lord Jesus Christ."